economic reform and liberalization (1983–86). On my first posting, I witnessed a China that had closed its doors on the world and embraced a drab and austere life while creating a ‘socialist paradise’, rejecting its own rich culture and traditions as obstacles to its modernization. In the words of China’s leader Mao Zedong, who wanted to wipe the slate clean so that a new China could be built:

> On a blank sheet of paper free of any mark, the freshest and most beautiful characters can be written; the freshest and most beautiful pictures can be painted. [1]

And yet, reminders of China’s long-standing history, the richness of its culture and its complex and sophisticated aesthetics, were present everywhere. There was an extraordinarily rich cuisine that one could savour in Beijing’s famed restaurants, and there were hidden alleys where precious antiques could be found for sale.

Our sources of information were sparse. There was virtually no access to Chinese officials, except to those assigned to deal with diplomats. There was only official media – the *People’s Daily* , the *Guang Ming Daily* and *Red Flag* magazine. Diplomats who knew Chinese had to read their weighty offerings with great care and attention, trying to discover political messages being conveyed through cryptic language or through reference to some bygone event in history. Contemporary political characters could be attacked through a campaign of criticism against some philosopher or ruler in the past. For example, when the radical leftist leaders allied to Mao Zedong’s wife Jiang Qing wanted to sideline Premier Zhou Enlai in 1975, they launched a mass campaign to criticize the ancient Chinese philosopher Confucius. From the context it was obvious that their real target was Zhou. This was confirmed later when Jiang Qing herself was arrested and removed from all her Party positions after Mao’s death in September 1976.

With the Reform and Opening-Up Policy launched in 1978, China began to undergo a rapid and far-reaching transformation. When I arrived for my second assignment in Beijing in 1983, it was to a China that was truly unrecognizable. There was something of a Wild West atmosphere as people